

**"BEING A WOMAN IS
A TERRIBLY DIFFICULT
TASK, SINCE IT CONSISTS
PRINCIPALLY IN
DEALING WITH MEN."**

Joseph Conrad (1857–1924),
British author

FATHER FIGURE

A patriarchal society places men as the dominant figures, with more power over the women and children. In these cultures, women concern themselves with keeping the house clean and the children fed. Religions, such as Christianity, have a male god as the creator of people, despite the fact that women are the biological carriers of children. There are exceptions in traditionally patriarchal setups, though—England, for example, has had three reigning queens.

WARTIME ROLES

During World War I and II, many husbands were overseas in combat, leaving their wives to stay at home to look after the house and children. In charge of running the household and with no patriarchal figures around, women had to step in and do "men's work." In World War II, many American women went to work in factories and other traditionally male-dominated trades. This also contributed to changing attitudes about gender roles as women became more empowered.

SIGN OF THE TIMES

Gender roles may change over time. Today, in many Western cultures, it is not unusual for a woman to work full time and have the same job as a man. However, there are still some differences in pay between men and women, and politics remains male dominated, though there are more female leaders than before. An area of significant change is family setup as same-sex families become more common.